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THE UNLOCKING OF A 42-YEAR MYSTERY

For decades, an Elgin cold case grew colder. Then two detectives started a podcast

Story by Andrew Carter | Photos by Stacey Wescott | Chicago Tribune

Before two Elgin police detectives used a podcast to help solve a mystery that endured for more than 40 years, they first had to figure out what podcasting was, exactly, and how it worked. It's not the sort of thing they teach at the police academy.

Andrew Houghton and Matt Vartanian knew some things about the medium, at least. As two 40-somethingss who'd worked their way up in their profession, they've listened to their share of true crime podcasts.

But to put one together, themselves, and host it? To investigate the most difficult cases, often ones that have gone unsolved for decades, and take an audience along for the ride for the improbable victories and inevitable failures? To share with the world their search for Karen Schepers, a young Elgin woman missing for more than 40 years?

The detectives wondered if they could do it and, at first, wondered if it could even help. That was their first reaction about a regular



At top, Elgin police Detectives Andrew Houghton, left, and Matt Vartanian stand Friday on the bank of the Fox River upriver from where the car and remains of Karen Schepers, above, were found in late March.

show dedicated to cold cases: Doubt. Apprehension.

Their boss pushed them to do it, anyway. Less than a year ago, Houghton, 41, and Vartanian, 42, were both working major investigations at the Elgin Police Department, about 35 miles northwest of Chicago in Illinois' sixth-largest city. Their cases often involved the worst of the worst. Vartanian came up in the department's gang unit, where shootings and firearms offenses occupied a lot of his time.

Houghton, meanwhile, spent about a decade investigating sex crimes against children. He'd come to tell people "they're bad cases, but good cases" — the good being that they were often black and white, with little gray area.

Last year their police chief, Ana Lalley, received some good news: She finally had

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Is mayor 'brick wall' to ethics reforms?

Johnson draws critics but argues policies should be broadened

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

When Mayor Brandon Johnson came into office, his hand-picked City Council ethics leader hoped the new mayor promising big change might truly reform the rules meant to keep elected officials in line in the famously corrupt city.

But then Johnson instead fought those efforts, Ethics Committee Chair Ald. Matt Martin said. And he has done so again and again.

"I came in the term expecting that we would be focused on ambitious reforms that restore the public's trust in City Hall," Martin said. "But instead I've had to focus on what should be the absolute bare minimum, fighting tooth and nail just to preserve the status quo."

In the last year, Johnson unsuccessfully resisted Martin's effort to codify old rules banning lobbyists from donating to mayoral candidates. He blasted Inspector General Deborah Witzburg's report that he mishandled gifts and is fighting her again as she alleges his Law Department hinders investigations.

Witzburg said Johnson's pattern of resistance amounts to "brick walls" at each step in her attempts at reform.

Martin said Johnson's team recently considered pushing him out of his Ethics Committee chairmanship, a charge the administration denies. And the mayor will soon face a similar big test: This fall, Johnson must decide if he will reappoint Witzburg to another four-year term.

For his part, the mayor appears to feel unfairly attacked by the reform bids, many of which he has argued should be broadened to also target aldermen or are simply bad policy. Asked Tuesday about his approach to ethics, he responded by listing off efforts

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AUDREY RICHARDSON/TRIBUNE

Sox look to right the ship before it sinks

Can the White Sox dig out of another early-season hole? A walk-off win Saturday is a start. Paul Sullivan in Chicago Sports

Trump's moves stun US importers

Over the years, U.S. companies have set up supply chains that rely on China. Tariffs are putting them in a bind. Nation & World

Trump's affinity for coal can't compete with market realities

By Michael Hawthorne
Chicago Tribune

Surrounded by coal miners, President Donald Trump signed an executive order vowing to roll back his predecessor's policies limiting lung-damaging, climate-changing pollution from power plants that burn the planet's dirtiest source of energy.

"C'mon, fellas, you know what this says?" Trump said to the men in hard hats. "You're going back to work!"

During the four years after the Republican president signed that 2017 order, and attempted to roll back dozens of clean air and water protections, 79 coal plants closed and 13,000 industry workers lost their jobs.

The number of plant closures and layoffs under Trump far exceeded those during President Barack Obama's second term and President Joe Biden's

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Miners drive down to a coal mine near Marissa, Illinois, in 2011. The mine is part of Prairie State Generating Co. ZBIGNIEW BZDAK/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

